

FOREWORD

Water is fundamental to sustainable development, human well-being, and planetary health. When water systems fail, the effects are swift and far-reaching: harvests decline, energy systems are disrupted, public health is endangered, cities become increasingly unlivable, livelihoods are lost, communities are displaced, tensions escalate, and the foundations of peace and stability are undermined. In the context of climate change, biodiversity loss, land degradation, and growing inequalities, water insecurity has emerged as a systemic risk that increasingly constrains progress across the entire 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

As the United Nations system marks three decades of the United Nations University Institute for Water, Environment and Health (UNU-INWEH), a longstanding advocate and global leader in water research, policy, and capacity-building since its establishment in Canada in 1996, this flagship report sheds light on one of the defining challenges of our time. Across regions and levels of development, water systems are under unprecedented pressure. Rivers, lakes and wetlands are degrading, groundwater resources are being depleted beyond sustainable limits, and glaciers are retreating at accelerating rates. These trends signal not only growing stress, but in many contexts a structural imbalance between water demand and available resources. This report refers to this condition as “Water Bankruptcy” and calls for effective action to protect water-related natural capital before damages become fully irreversible.

The concept of water bankruptcy draws attention to the evidence that societies rely on both renewable water flows and long-term natural storage, comparable to drawing on income and savings, and that in many basins and aquifers sustained withdrawals have exceeded renewable replenishment and safe depletion thresholds. As a result, available water resources and associated ecosystem functions have been significantly reduced, with some impacts irreversible or effectively irreversible on human time scales.

Recognizing the era of water bankruptcy, as articulated in this report, can support more effective implementation of internationally agreed goals. It enables a shift from fragmented and reactive responses toward integrated, forward-looking approaches grounded in current and projected hydrological realities. It supports strategies to prevent further irreversible damage, rebalance water use within degraded limits, and promote just and inclusive transitions for affected communities, consistent with the commitment to leave no one behind.

Water is explicitly addressed in Sustainable Development Goal 6, which commits the international community to ensure the availability and sustainable

management of water and sanitation for all. At the same time, progress across almost every other Sustainable Development Goal depends directly or indirectly on the stability and integrity of water systems. Despite this centrality, water governance and water-related decision-making remain fragmented across sectors, scales, and institutions. As a result, water-related risks increasingly constrain collective efforts to deliver on the 2030 Agenda. The report encourages positioning water as a catalyst for unlocking co-benefits across the Rio Conventions and the Sustainable Development Goals, a valuable opportunity that cannot be overlooked. Strengthened policy coherence and integrated action are therefore required across the United Nations system and multilateral processes, including those related to climate change, biodiversity, land degradation, disaster risk reduction, and peace and security, to unlock water’s true potential to connect communities and facilitate cooperation when unity is needed the most.

The timing of this report is critical. The period leading to the 2026 and 2028 UN Water Conferences, together with the conclusion of the International Decade for Action “Water for Sustainable Development” in 2028, represents a pivotal opportunity to accelerate implementation, strengthen accountability, and elevate water as a global priority. These milestones provide a platform to align commitments, partnerships, and investments with hydrological realities and long-term resilience, and to plan and implement policies that reflect the water resources available under current and future conditions.

With coordinated leadership, integrated approaches, and sustained investment, water can serve as a catalyst for cooperation, resilience, and shared prosperity. The decisions taken in the coming years will shape development outcomes across People, Planet, Prosperity, Peace, and Partnerships for decades to come.



Tshilidzi Marwala
Rector of the United Nations
University
Under-Secretary-General of the
United Nations



Terry Duguid
Member of Parliament
Chair of Standing Committee of
Natural Resources
House of Commons of Canada